

POLITICIAN 1916–2009

ROBERT McNAMARA

Defense secretary from 1960 until 1968 for presidents Kennedy and Johnson, Robert McNamara had previously been president of the Ford Motor Company and had served in World War II in the US Army Air Forces. As defense secretary, McNamara used statistics such as body counts to measure the success of combat operations. The reasons for his departure from office remain unclear. After leaving government, he became head of the World Bank (1968–81).



» AFTER

By the fall of 1965, the United States was fully engaged in a ground war in South Vietnam and an air war over North Vietnam.

POLITICAL STABILITY

The deepening involvement of US forces provided a measure of political stability in the South, as it finally **elected a president**—Nguyen Van Thieu, an ARVN general who had supported the overthrow of Diem. He would remain in office for the war's duration.

EFFECTS ON THE POPULATION

The US presence also dramatically altered life for the South Vietnamese people as the war engulfed ever-increasing areas of the country. Moreover, the war failed to stem growing **communist insurgency** or to counter North Vietnam's continuing attempts to claim South Vietnam.